CITALOPRAM

QT prolongation

Max 20 mg in elderly

CHEMICAL NAME (RS)-1-[3-(dimethylamino)propyl]-1-(4-fluorophenyl)-1,3-dihydro-2-benzofuran-5-carbonitrile (hydrobromide)

CLASS Selective serotonin reuptake inhibitor (SSRI)

TRADE NAMES Cipramil · Celexa · Cipram · Recital

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Major depression.
- Panic disorder (with/without agoraphobia).
- Off-label: anxiety, agitation in dementia (low dose).

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO** once daily, any time, with or without food.
- Oral drops: 8 mg (4 drops) ≈ 10 mg tablet.

DOSAGES

- **Depression:** 20 mg once daily; max 40 mg.
- **Panic:** start 10 mg, increase to 20–30 mg.
- **Elderly >65, hepatic impairment, CYP2C19 poor metabolisers:** max 20 mg.

PHARMACOKINETICS

- **Onset:** 2–4 weeks.
- Metabolised by CYP2C19, 3A4, 2D6.
- **t½:** 36 h.

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- Highly selective **5-HT reuptake** inhibitor.

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Nausea, dry mouth, sweating.
- Somnolence or insomnia.
- Sexual dysfunction.

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- Dose-dependent QT prolongation, torsades.
- Hyponatraemia (elderly).
- Suicidality; serotonin syndrome; bleeding.

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- Known QT prolongation or congenital long QT; use with other QT-prolonging drugs.
- MAOIs; linezolid; pimozide.

KEY INTERACTIONS

- **QT drugs (antipsychotics, macrolides, ondansetron, methadone):** avoid.
- **Omeprazole, fluconazole (CYP2C19):** ↑ levels.
- **Serotonergic drugs:** serotonin syndrome.

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- ECG in cardiac disease/QT risk; check K^+, Mg^{2+}.
- Na^+ in elderly.
- Mood and suicide risk monitoring.

PATIENT EDUCATION

- Report palpitations or fainting.
- Effects take weeks; do not stop suddenly.
- Report worsening mood.

KEY POINTS

- SSRI; QT prolongation dose-related.
- Avoid with other QT drugs.
- 20 mg; max 40 mg (20 mg elderly).
- Hyponatraemia in elderly.

SOURCES CHECKED **[774]** Citalopram 40 mg Tablets (UK SmPC) **[775]** Citalopram, oral (US label) **[776]** Citalopram, oral (US label, Chartwell Governmental & Specialty RX)

Full references p. 432–457